

UNIT X

Toward a More Perfect Union

Modern America · 1964–Present



US.83

US.84

US.85

US.86

US.87

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US.89

US.90

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US.94

US.95

ESSENTIAL QUESTION

This is the last stop, and it runs right up to your own front door. In sixty years America argued about almost everything — how big government should be, whether it could be trusted, what it owed the poor and the planet, how to keep itself safe, and who was allowed to lead. It broke a president, ended a Cold War, was attacked on its own soil, and elected a Black president in the same century a Tennessee balcony took the movement's greatest leader. After 130 years of watching the gap between America's promise and its practice, the last question is the one only you can answer: is the union still becoming more perfect — and what will you do with it?

You made it to the last stop — and this one ends at the present, with the pen in your hand. Over the past sixty years, America argued its way through almost everything: how much its government should do (the Great Society), whether that government could even be trusted (Watergate), what it owed the poor and the planet, how to survive an economy gone haywire, how to end a Cold War without a war, how to respond when it was attacked on its own soil, and who was allowed to lead. You'll travel with three people who span it all. Danny, the boomer you've known since he hid under a desk in the 1950s, lives the whole arc — protester, worker, voter. Diane carries her activist conscience from Vietnam to the first Earth Day. And Maya — a Memphis teenager, the granddaughter of a civil-rights marcher you already met — grows up with a phone in her pocket, watches the towers fall, and casts her first vote for the first Black president. Tennessee threads through to the very end: the senator who cracked Watergate, a tiny fish that stopped a dam, the soldiers of Fort Campbell, the Tennessean who helped build the internet. And then the story runs out of past — and becomes your turn.

How this unit works

- Taught through story — you live the modern era through a boomer, an activist, and a teenager of today.
- Multiple perspectives — on the era's genuinely contested questions (government's size, trade, security, spending), the unit gives the honest arguments, not a verdict.
- Primary sources — Johnson, Nixon, Baker, Reagan, and the Court in their own words, plus the era's defining photographs.
- UDL — a present-day hook, plain-language summaries, cited images, and a choice of ways to respond on every spread.
- Recent history, handled fairly — the closer we get to now, the more carefully the unit presents debates as debates for you to weigh.
- The Arc of the Union — the whole 130-year trajectory closes here, and you decide where it points next.

Flight crew this unit:

[Archive \(J. Troop\)](#)

[Spark](#)

[Navigator](#)

[Notetaker](#)

Who you'll travel with in this unit



Danny, 20

America, aging across
the decades



Diane, 22

An American campus,
then the wider
movement



Maya, 17

Memphis, Tennessee
→ college

Spread 1 · US.83, US.84

Analyze Johnson's Great Society and the 1960s counterculture as two very different responses to the question of what America should become.

 Two revolutions at once. In Washington, a president tries to build a 'Great Society' — declaring war on poverty itself and creating health care for the old and the poor. Out in the streets and on the campuses, a whole generation of young people grows its hair long, cranks up the music, and declares war on its parents' entire way of life. The 1960s asked the biggest question a country can ask — what kind of society do we want to be? — and got two loud, clashing answers.

Archive splits the screen: a president signing a landmark law in one frame, a field of 400,000 young people at a music festival in the other. 'Same country, same decade, two dreams of the future,' she says. 'One built through government, one through rebellion. Watch them both — and notice they don't quite fit together.'

PRIMARY VOICE

Lyndon Johnson · the Great Society

Riding the momentum of the civil-rights movement, President Lyndon Johnson launched the most ambitious domestic agenda since the New Deal. He called it the Great Society, and its goal was breathtaking: to 'end poverty and racial injustice' through the power of the federal government. In 1965 he signed Medicare and Medicaid into law, giving health coverage to the elderly and the poor — programs that still protect tens of millions today. His War on Poverty funded education, job training, and community programs. The results were genuinely mixed — poverty fell but was not conquered, and some urban-renewal projects displaced the very neighborhoods they meant to save. But Johnson had expanded, once again, what Americans could ask their government to do.



ERA-FRIEND

Danny • the generation gap

Danny, now in college, is living the other revolution. He and millions of young people open a wide 'generation gap,' rejecting their parents' values, their materialism, their deference to authority, and — above all — their war in Vietnam. Some become 'hippies,' embracing peace, love, communal living, and music that horrifies their elders; in 1969, around 400,000 of them gather at the Woodstock festival. Danny isn't sure he buys all of it, but he feels the pull: the sense that the shiny, conformist world he grew up in (the world of Unit 8) was hiding too much, and that his generation is going to tear it open and build something freer. The counterculture reshapes American music, fashion, and attitudes — and splits the country between those who cheer it and those who fear it.



📷 President Johnson signs Medicare and Medicaid into law in 1965 (with former President Truman beside him) — a cornerstone of the Great Society.

'President Johnson signs the Medicare bill, Truman Library.' Photograph, July 30, 1965. U.S. government (public domain).

💡 This is President Johnson signing Medicare in 1965, with former President Truman — who had tried and failed to pass health insurance — beside him. Ask: Medicare still covers older Americans today, sixty years later. What does it mean that a law signed before your grandparents were grown still shapes your family now?

MORE FROM THE RECORD



About 100,000 anti-war protesters near the Lincoln Memorial, October 1967 — the counterculture and the antiwar movement converging.



U.S. soldiers deploy from 'Huey' helicopters in Vietnam, 1967 — the war whose length and cost fueled the era's generational rebellion.

In plain words: The 1960s brought two big changes at once. In government, President Johnson's Great Society tried to end poverty and injustice: Medicare and Medicaid (1965) gave health coverage to the elderly and the poor, and the War on Poverty funded education and jobs (with mixed results). In the streets, the counterculture opened a 'generation gap' — young people like Danny rejected their parents' values, materialism, and the Vietnam War, embracing peace, music, and freedom (400,000 gathered at Woodstock in 1969). Both reshaped America, and they didn't always agree.

● **Tennessee:** The Great Society reached into Tennessee's hardest-hit corners. The War on Poverty targeted regions like East Tennessee's Appalachian counties — among the poorest in the nation — funding schools, health clinics, and job programs, while Medicare and Medicaid brought health coverage to elderly and low-income Tennesseans statewide. For many Tennessee families, Johnson's programs were not abstract politics; they were a doctor's visit their parents could finally afford.

Toward a more perfect union — the cycle

- **Problem:** Persistent poverty and injustice, and a generation's discontent with mainstream values and war.
- **Head out of the sand:** Reformers in government (Johnson) and rebellious youth in the streets.
- **Voice raised:** Landmark legislation on one side; protest, music, and cultural rebellion on the other.
- **Government response:** The Great Society expanded the federal safety net (Medicare, Medicaid, War on Poverty).
- **Still unfinished:** Debates over government's role in fighting poverty — and over cultural change — continue today.

✓ **Check:** Describe two major programs of the Great Society and their goals. Then explain what the 'generation gap' and counterculture were rejecting. How were these two 1960s movements different visions of America's future?

Show what you know:

- Make a two-column chart: how the Great Society and the counterculture each tried to change America.
 - Write Danny's letter home explaining the generation gap to parents who don't understand it.
 - Debate: which did more to shape modern America — the Great Society's laws or the counterculture's cultural change? Use evidence.
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Spread 2 · US.85, US.86

Analyze Nixon's 'silent majority' strategy and China opening, and the Watergate scandal that proved no one is above the law.

 A president pulls off one of the boldest moves in the history of American diplomacy — flying to communist China to shake the hand of a man his whole career said was the enemy. And then the same president destroys himself, not with the break-in his people ordered, but with the cover-up and the lie. Richard Nixon is the great paradox of modern politics: a leader capable of brilliance and of the crime that would teach America to never fully trust its presidents again.

Archive shows the crew two images of the same man: shaking hands with Chairman Mao in Beijing, and flashing a defiant V from a helicopter as he flees the White House in disgrace. 'Two years apart,' she says. 'The heights and the fall. Watch how a democracy handles a president who breaks the law — because that test is the whole point.'

INSTITUTION

Nixon · the silent majority and the world

Richard Nixon won the presidency by speaking to what he called the 'silent majority' — mainstream Americans, uneasy with the decade's protests and upheaval, who he said weren't marching in the streets. It was the start of a new conservative coalition that would reshape American politics. In office, Nixon surprised everyone. He pursued détente with the Soviets and, in a stunning 1972 trip, opened relations with communist China after more than twenty years of hostility, changing the global balance of power. And despite his conservative image, he signed the law creating the Environmental Protection Agency. Nixon proved the era's politics were messier than any label — which made what came next all the more shocking.



ERA-FRIEND

Danny · learning not to trust

Danny, now a working adult, watches Watergate unfold and feels something in the country break. It began as a 1972 burglary at Democratic Party headquarters, but investigative journalists and a Senate committee slowly uncovered something far worse: a cover-up run from the White House itself. When the Supreme Court, in *United States v. Nixon* (1974), forced the release of secret tapes proving Nixon had helped hide the crime, he became the only president in history to resign. For Danny's generation — already skeptical from Vietnam — Watergate was the final lesson: their government would lie to them. The lasting distrust it bred, and the warnings about an 'imperial presidency,' still shape how Americans see their leaders.



📷 President Nixon flashes a V-sign as he leaves the White House on August 9, 1974 — the only U.S. president ever to resign, brought down by Watergate.

'President Nixon departing the White House after resignation.' Photograph, August 9, 1974. Public domain.

💡 This is Nixon leaving the White House the day he resigned in 1974 — still flashing victory as he flew away in disgrace. Ask: the system worked — the courts, the Congress, and the press forced a president out for breaking the law. Is that a story of American failure, or American strength?

MORE FROM THE RECORD



President Nixon shakes hands with Chairman Mao in Beijing, 1972 — the first U.S.-China meeting in over 20 years and a Cold War breakthrough.

In plain words: Richard Nixon won by appealing to the 'silent majority' of Americans tired of 1960s protest, building a new conservative coalition. He surprised the world by opening relations with communist China in 1972 and, despite being conservative, created the EPA. But the Watergate scandal destroyed him: a 1972 break-in at Democratic headquarters led to a White House cover-up, and when the Supreme Court (*United States v. Nixon*, 1974) forced release of secret tapes proving his guilt, he resigned — the only president ever to do so. It taught America that no one is above the law, but also bred lasting distrust of government.

● **Tennessee:** A Tennessean asked the question that defined Watergate. Senator Howard Baker Jr. of Tennessee, the top Republican on the Senate Watergate Committee, cut through the scandal with a single line: 'What did the President know, and when did he know it?' A respected consensus-builder who put the investigation above his own party's president, Baker became one of the most admired Tennesseans in modern politics — proof that holding power accountable is not disloyalty, but its highest form.

Toward a more perfect union — the cycle

- **Problem:** A president's administration broke the law and tried to cover it up from inside the White House.
- **Head out of the sand:** Investigative journalists, a bipartisan Senate committee (including Howard Baker), and the courts.
- **Voice raised:** A free press, congressional hearings, and the judicial process.
- **Government response:** The Supreme Court forced release of the tapes; facing impeachment, Nixon resigned.
- **Still unfinished:** Guarding against abuses of presidential power — the 'imperial presidency' — remains an ongoing concern.

✓ **Check:** Explain Nixon's 'silent majority' strategy and his opening to China. Then explain what Watergate was and why United States v. Nixon mattered. What does Watergate teach about limits on presidential power?

Show what you know:

- Explain how three institutions — press, Congress, courts — each helped hold Nixon accountable.
 - Write a short profile of Howard Baker arguing why putting country over party is patriotism.
 - Debate: was Watergate mainly a story of American failure or of American institutions working? Use evidence.
-

Spread 3 · US.87

Analyze the rise of the modern environmental movement and its landmark laws and conflicts.

🔊 A river so polluted it literally caught fire. A book that revealed the pesticides in your food were killing the birds. A neighborhood built on a buried chemical dump. By the late 1960s, Americans looked around at the cost of a century of unchecked industry — the smog, the poisoned water, the vanishing wildlife — and decided that 'progress' had a bill coming due. Out of that alarm came a brand-new idea in American life: that protecting the planet was everyone's job.

Archive brings the crew to a sea of people at the first Earth Day. Diane is in the crowd, older now, still marching. 'She protested a war,' Archive says. 'Now she's found the next fight — one that doesn't take sides between nations, but between us and the mess we've made. Watch a whole new cause be born.'



ERA-FRIEND

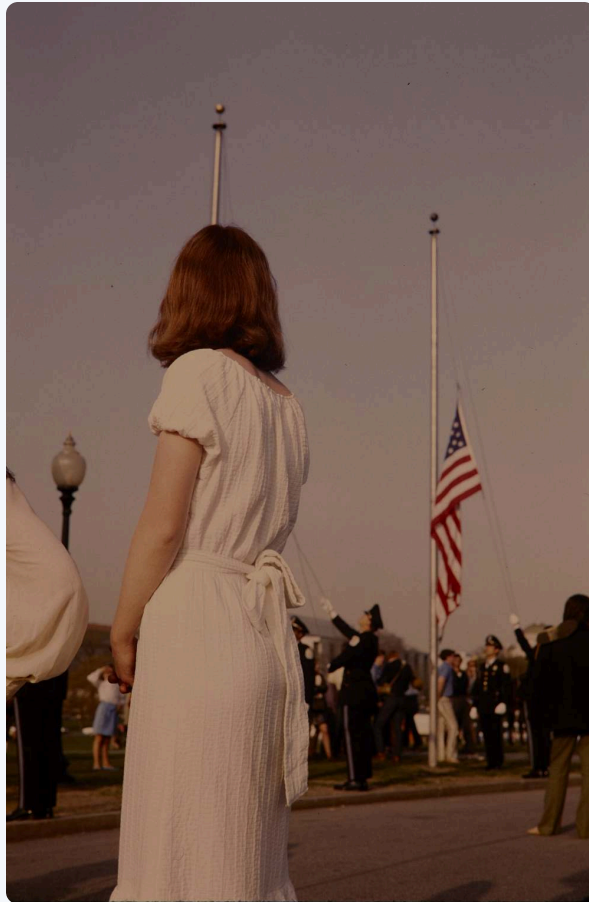
Diane · the next great cause

Diane carried her activist conscience out of the antiwar movement and into what became the defining cause of her later years: the environment. She reads Rachel Carson's *Silent Spring* (1962), which exposed how pesticides were poisoning the natural world, and she joins the first Earth Day on April 22, 1970 — a demonstration so vast, some 20 million Americans took part, that it launched the modern environmental movement overnight. To Diane, it's the same fight as before in a new form: refusing to let the powerful treat the world as something to be used up and thrown away. And this time, remarkably, the movement wins fast, and it wins in law.

INSTITUTION

Turning alarm into law

The environmental movement produced results with startling speed. Within a few years the country created the Environmental Protection Agency to regulate pollution, and passed the Clean Air Act and the Clean Water Act to force industry to stop fouling the nation's skies and rivers. When the Love Canal disaster revealed a neighborhood poisoned by buried toxic waste, Congress created the Superfund program to clean up such sites. And after the frightening Three Mile Island nuclear accident in 1979, the expansion of nuclear power in America ground to a halt. In one decade, protecting the environment went from a fringe idea to a permanent part of American law and life.



📷 The first Earth Day at the Washington Monument, April 22, 1970 — about 20 million Americans took part, launching the modern environmental movement.

'Earth Day flag ceremony at the Washington Monument.' Photograph, April 22, 1970. Public domain.

💡 This is the first Earth Day, April 22, 1970 — about 20 million Americans took part. Ask: in just a few years, 'protect the environment' went from a fringe idea to national law. What makes an idea spread that fast — and what causes today do you think could move that quickly?

In plain words: By the late 1960s, Americans were alarmed by pollution — smog, poisoned rivers, dying wildlife. Rachel Carson's book *Silent Spring* (1962) exposed the dangers of pesticides, and the first Earth Day (1970) drew about 20 million people, launching the modern environmental movement. It won fast: the country created the Environmental Protection Agency (EPA) and passed the Clean Air Act and Clean Water Act. After the Love Canal toxic-waste disaster, Congress created the Superfund cleanup program, and the Three Mile Island nuclear accident (1979) stopped the growth of nuclear power. Protecting the environment became a permanent American cause.

● **Tennessee:** One of the movement's most famous battles was fought over a tiny Tennessee fish. When the TVA's Tellico Dam in East Tennessee threatened an endangered species called the snail darter, the case went all the way to the Supreme Court as *TVA v. Hill* (1978) — and the Court upheld the new Endangered Species Act, halting the dam to save the fish. It was a landmark clash between old-style development (the TVA you met in Unit 5) and the new environmental movement, and it happened in Tennessee.

Toward a more perfect union — the cycle

- **Problem:** A century of unchecked industry had polluted the air, water, and land and endangered wildlife.
- **Head out of the sand:** Scientists (Rachel Carson), activists, and the 20 million who marched on the first Earth Day.
- **Voice raised:** Books, mass demonstrations (Earth Day), and public pressure.
- **Government response:** The government created the EPA and passed the Clean Air, Clean Water, and Superfund laws.
- **Still unfinished:** Balancing environmental protection with development, energy, and jobs — and now climate change — is ongoing.

✓ **Check:** Explain what sparked the modern environmental movement and describe two laws or agencies it created. Then explain the conflict the snail-darter case revealed. Why might environmental protection sometimes clash with other goals?

Show what you know:

- Design a poster for the first Earth Day, then note which of its demands became law.
 - Argue both sides of the snail-darter case: the dam's builders and the fish's defenders.
 - Debate: when environmental protection and jobs conflict, how should a democracy decide? Use evidence.
-

Spread 4 • US.88

Analyze Carter's presidency — stagflation and the energy crisis, the Camp David triumph, and the Iran Hostage Crisis.

🔊 Imagine prices going up AND jobs disappearing at the same time — the two things that aren't supposed to happen together, both happening at once. Add gas stations with lines around the block and no fuel to sell. That was the 1970s economy, and it broke the old rules. Into that mess stepped Jimmy Carter, a president who would achieve one of the greatest peace deals in modern history — and be undone by 52 Americans held hostage on the far side of the world.

Archive lands the crew in a line of cars stretching from an empty gas station. 'The mighty postwar economy you saw in Unit 8 has hit a wall,' she says. 'Watch a decent, hardworking president wrestle a crisis that didn't follow any rulebook — and win a miracle in one place while losing the country in another.'



ERA-FRIEND

Danny • squeezed by stagflation

Danny is a working adult now with a family, and the 1970s economy is squeezing him from both sides. Economists have a strange new word for it: stagflation — high inflation and high unemployment at the same time, a combination the old theories said shouldn't be possible. Prices climb faster than Danny's paycheck, and jobs feel shaky. On top of it, an energy crisis sends oil prices soaring and leaves gas stations dry, with cars lined up for blocks. The optimism of Danny's youth — the booming, anything-is-possible America of the 1950s and '60s — has curdled into something harder. For the first time, Danny wonders whether his kids will have it better than he did.

INSTITUTION

Carter • a triumph and a trap

Jimmy Carter's presidency held both a mountaintop and a pit. The mountaintop was Camp David: in 1978, Carter personally spent thirteen days mediating between the leaders of Egypt and Israel — nations that had fought war after war — and brokered a historic peace agreement, leading to a formal treaty in 1979. It was one of the great diplomatic achievements of the century. The pit was Iran: after Iranian revolutionaries seized the U.S. embassy in 1979, 52 Americans were held hostage for 444 days, and Carter's inability to free them, broadcast nightly, made him look helpless. The hostage crisis, on top of the bad economy, helped Ronald Reagan defeat Carter in 1980.



📷 Sadat, Carter, and Begin join hands at the Camp David Accords, 1978 — Carter's greatest foreign-policy success, a peace between Egypt and Israel.

'Sadat, Carter, and Begin at the Camp David Accords signing.' Photograph, September 17, 1978. U.S. government (public domain).

💡 This is Carter joining the hands of Egypt's Sadat and Israel's Begin at the 1978 Camp David Accords — two old enemies making peace. Ask: this is often called Carter's greatest achievement, yet he lost the next election. What does that tell you about how presidents get judged — and whether that judgment is fair?

In plain words: President Jimmy Carter faced a rough economy: 'stagflation' (high inflation AND high unemployment at once) and an energy crisis with soaring oil prices and gas lines. His greatest success was the Camp David Accords (1978), where he personally brokered a historic peace between Egypt and Israel. But his presidency was crippled by the Iran Hostage Crisis — 52 Americans held for 444 days after Iranian revolutionaries seized the U.S. embassy — which, along with the bad economy, helped Ronald Reagan defeat him in 1980.

● **Tennessee:** Through these turbulent years, Tennessee's Howard Baker was a steady hand in Washington. Having earned national respect during Watergate, Baker served as the Senate's Republican leader during the Carter years, helping shape the era's fierce debates over energy, the economy, and foreign policy. A Tennessean known for working across the aisle, he was one of the most influential figures in the government wrestling with the decade's crises.

✓ **Check:** Explain what 'stagflation' and the energy crisis were and how they affected Americans. Then contrast Carter's greatest success (Camp David) with his greatest failure (Iran). Was Carter's reputation as a 'failed' president fair? Defend your answer.

Show what you know:

- Explain stagflation with a simple before/after picture of a 1970s family's budget.
 - Write two headlines about Carter — one about Camp David, one about Iran — and explain which the public remembered.
 - Debate: was Jimmy Carter a failed president or an unlucky one? Use evidence.
-

Spread 5 • US.89

Analyze the Reagan Revolution — its economic policy, its social costs and conflicts, and its Cold War pressure on the Soviet Union.

 After a decade of gas lines, hostages, and self-doubt, a former movie actor stood up and told Americans it was 'Morning in America' again — that the country's best days were ahead, that government was the problem, and that the way forward was to cut taxes, build up the military, and stand tall against communism. Millions believed him, and it launched a conservative revolution that still shapes your politics today. Like everything in this unit, it was a revolution with both a bright side and a bill.

Archive brings the crew to the Brandenburg Gate as a president dares the Soviet leader to tear down a wall. 'This is Reagan at the height of his confidence,' she says. 'His supporters say he revived the country and helped win the Cold War. His critics point to the debt and the people left behind. Your job is to weigh both — honestly.'

PRIMARY VOICE

Ronald Reagan • Morning in America

Ronald Reagan transformed American politics with sunny optimism and a clear message: government had grown too big, and freedom and free markets were the answer. His economic program, 'Reaganomics,' cut taxes sharply and boosted military spending, betting that a freed-up economy would grow for everyone. The economy did grow — but the tax cuts plus the military buildup also roughly tripled the national debt. On the world stage, Reagan confronted the Soviet Union aggressively, matching its arsenal and, at the Berlin Wall in 1987, demanding, 'Mr. Gorbachev, tear down this wall!' To his admirers, that pressure helped bring the Cold War to an end. Reagan reshaped what many Americans expected from their government.

GROUP

The other ledger • costs and conflicts

Every revolution has a ledger, and the Reagan era's had hard entries the celebration often skips. His War on Drugs, meant to fight addiction and crime, helped drive a massive rise in incarceration that fell with sharp and lasting racial disparities on Black and brown communities. The AIDS epidemic exploded during these years, and the federal government's slow response was widely criticized as a moral failure that cost lives. Deep tax cuts strained programs for the poor even as the economy grew, widening the gap between rich and poor. None of this erases what Reagan's supporters valued — but an honest account of the era holds the optimism and the costs on the same page.



📷 President Reagan at the Brandenburg Gate, 1987, where he demanded 'Mr. Gorbachev, tear down this wall!' — two years before the wall fell.

'President Reagan speech at the Berlin Wall, Brandenburg Gate.' Photograph, June 12, 1987. U.S. government (public domain).

💡 This is Reagan demanding 'tear down this wall!' at the Berlin Wall in 1987 — two years before it fell. Ask: historians still debate how much Reagan's pressure actually caused the Soviet collapse versus forces already at work inside the USSR. How do you weigh a leader's role against the bigger tides of history?

MORE FROM THE RECORD



The Space Shuttle Challenger explodes 73 seconds after launch, January 28, 1986, killing all seven aboard including teacher Christa McAuliffe.

In plain words: Ronald Reagan led a conservative revolution with optimistic 'Morning in America' messaging. His 'Reaganomics' cut taxes and increased military spending — the economy grew, but the national debt roughly tripled. He confronted the Soviet Union aggressively and, at the Berlin Wall in 1987, demanded Gorbachev 'tear down this wall'; supporters credit this with helping end the Cold War. But the era also had costs: the War on Drugs drove mass incarceration with sharp racial disparities, the government's slow AIDS response was widely criticized, and inequality grew. An honest account holds both the optimism and the costs.

● **Tennessee:** Tennessee felt the Reagan era's optimism firsthand. In 1982, Knoxville hosted a World's Fair on the theme of energy — a hopeful, forward-looking spectacle that drew millions of visitors after the gloom of the 1970s energy crisis. It was a moment of civic pride and confidence in Tennessee that matched the national mood Reagan was tapping, even as the state, like the country, debated the era's harder trade-offs.

Toward a more perfect union — the cycle

- **Problem:** After the troubled 1970s, Americans debated how big government should be and how to confront the Soviet Union.
- **Head out of the sand:** A new conservative movement, and critics who warned of debt, inequality, and neglected crises.
- **Voice raised:** Elections, tax policy, and public debate over government's proper size and role.
- **Government response:** Reagan cut taxes, expanded the military, and pressured the USSR; debates over the results continue.
- **Still unfinished:** The size-of-government debate Reagan reignited still defines American politics.

✓ **Check:** Explain 'Reaganomics' and one result of it. Describe Reagan's approach to the Cold War. Then identify one social cost or conflict of the Reagan era. Why is it important to weigh both sides of this presidency?

Show what you know:

- Make a 'ledger' of the Reagan era: achievements on one side, costs on the other, with evidence.
 - Write two op-eds on Reagan's legacy — one admiring, one critical — each making its strongest honest case.
 - Debate: how much credit does Reagan deserve for ending the Cold War? Weigh his role against internal Soviet collapse.
-

Spread 6 · US.90

Analyze how George H.W. Bush managed the peaceful end of the Cold War and led a coalition in the Gulf War.

 The wall came down. The enemy America had feared for 45 years — the one with thousands of nuclear missiles aimed at your grandparents — simply crumbled, and then dissolved entirely, without the world-ending war everyone had dreaded. How a president handles a moment of total victory says everything about him. And barely a year later, that same president would build a coalition of the whole world to answer a dictator's invasion in the desert.

Archive brings the crew to the Oval Office as a president is handed a chunk of the fallen Berlin Wall. 'The Cold War you followed for a whole unit just ended,' she says. 'Watch how America wins gracefully — and then watch it go to war again, this time with the world at its side.'

INSTITUTION

The Cold War ends · victory with restraint

President George H.W. Bush had the delicate job of managing the end of the Cold War. The Berlin Wall fell in 1989 and the Soviet Union itself collapsed in 1991 — the enemy of half a century, gone. Bush's response was notably restrained: he deliberately refused to gloat or spike the football, understanding that humiliating a wounded, still nuclear-armed Soviet Union could be dangerous. It was a quiet kind of leadership, easy to overlook — the wisdom to win without crowing. The Cold War that had shadowed every unit since 1945 ended not in fire, as everyone had feared, but in a careful, peaceful transition that Bush helped steer.

GROUP

The Gulf War · the world responds

In 1990, Iraq's dictator Saddam Hussein invaded and seized the small, oil-rich nation of Kuwait. Bush's response became a model of coalition-building: rather than acting alone, he assembled a broad international coalition, backed by the United Nations, of dozens of nations. In early 1991, Operation Desert Storm unleashed overwhelming U.S. military technology and drove Iraqi forces out of Kuwait in a stunning 100-hour ground campaign — as retreating Iraqis set more than 600 oil wells ablaze. The war was a swift, popular success. But Bush's decision to stop there and leave Saddam Hussein in power in Iraq would be debated for years — and would echo loudly a decade later.



📷 Kuwaiti oil wells set ablaze by retreating Iraqi forces during the 1991 Gulf War — a U.S.-led coalition drove Iraq out of Kuwait in 100 hours.

'Kuwait oil-field fires during Operation Desert Storm.' Photograph, 1991. U.S. military (public domain).

💡 These are Kuwaiti oil wells set ablaze by retreating Iraqi forces in 1991 — an environmental disaster that burned for months. Ask: the Gulf War was a fast, popular military victory. What does an image of the destruction it left behind add to the story that the '100-hour victory' headline leaves out?

MORE FROM THE RECORD



President George H.W. Bush receives a piece of the Berlin Wall in the Oval Office, November 1989 — he responded to the Cold War's end without gloating.

In plain words: President George H.W. Bush managed the peaceful end of the Cold War: the Berlin Wall fell (1989) and the Soviet Union collapsed (1991), and Bush responded with restraint rather than gloating, to avoid humiliating a still-nuclear-armed rival. Then, after Iraq's dictator Saddam Hussein invaded Kuwait (1990), Bush assembled a broad UN-backed international coalition. Operation Desert Storm (1991) drove Iraq out of Kuwait in just 100 hours — though retreating Iraqis set 600+ oil wells on fire. Bush's choice to leave Saddam in power was debated for years.

● **Tennessee:** Tennessee soldiers were at the front of the Gulf War. Fort Campbell, on the Tennessee-Kentucky line, is home to the storied 101st Airborne Division — the 'Screaming Eagles' — which deployed to the 1991 Gulf War as part of the coalition that liberated Kuwait. When America answered Saddam Hussein's invasion, Tennessee-based troops were among the first sent to the desert, continuing the state's long history at the center of the nation's wars.

✓ **Check:** Explain how the Cold War ended under Bush and why his restraint mattered. Then describe the Gulf War and Bush's coalition-building approach. Why was leaving Saddam Hussein in power a debated decision?

Show what you know:

- Explain why a president might choose NOT to celebrate a huge victory, using Bush and the Cold War's end.
 - Make a case for and against Bush's decision to stop the Gulf War without removing Saddam Hussein.
 - Debate: was coalition-building or military technology more important to the Gulf War's success? Use evidence.
-

Analyze the Clinton-era economy and the communication-technology revolution that reshaped how Americans live.

💡 Somewhere in the 1990s, the whole world moved into your pocket. In a single generation, America went from landlines, letters, and encyclopedias on a shelf to the internet, email, and eventually a supercomputer in every hand. It rewired how people work, shop, learn, argue, and fall in love — the biggest change in daily life since the automobile. And it powered an economic boom that, for a few shining years, made the future look limitless.

Archive sets the crew in front of a beige 1980s computer, then fast-forwards through the decades to a glowing smartphone. Maya, a teenager, holds the phone like it's part of her hand. 'For her,' Archive says, 'a world without this is unimaginable. Watch the machine that rewired everything — and meet the generation that will never remember life before it.'



ERA-FRIEND

Maya • born connected

Maya has never known a world without the internet. The revolution that made her possible started before she was born — the IBM Personal Computer arrived in 1981 and moved computing out of labs and into homes and schools; the internet spread across the 1990s; and by Maya's childhood, smartphones and social media had put the entire connected world into a device she carries everywhere. To Maya it's simply air: she does homework, keeps up with friends, learns, shops, and argues online without a second thought. But she's also the first generation to grow up inside the revolution's shadows — the misinformation, the pressure, the loss of privacy. The technology that connects Maya to everything also connects everything to her.

INSTITUTION

The Clinton boom • prosperity and free trade

The technology revolution helped power a long economic boom in the 1990s under President Bill Clinton. Driven by the new internet and tech sector, the economy roared, and in a remarkable feat Clinton reached the first balanced federal budget since 1969. He also signed NAFTA (1993), the North American Free Trade Agreement, which removed trade barriers among the United States, Canada, and Mexico. NAFTA split Americans: supporters said free trade would expand markets and lower prices, while critics warned it would send factory jobs to Mexico — a debate over globalization that still rages. Clinton was impeached in 1998 over a personal scandal but acquitted by the Senate and remained popular through the boom.



📷 The original IBM Personal Computer (1981), which helped move computers into homes and schools — a first step toward the internet and smartphone age.

'IBM Personal Computer Model 5150.' Photograph, 1981. Public domain.

💡 This is the 1981 IBM Personal Computer — clunky, beige, and revolutionary. Ask: the device in your pocket is millions of times more powerful than this. In one human lifetime, computing went from this to that. What do you think the next forty years will do — and what should we be careful about?

MORE FROM THE RECORD



President Clinton promotes NAFTA with bipartisan leaders, 1993 — free trade that supporters said would grow markets and critics said would cost factory jobs.

In plain words: From the 1970s to today, communication technology transformed daily life: the personal computer (IBM PC, 1981) brought computers into homes and schools, the internet spread in the 1990s, and smartphones and social media followed. It reshaped how Americans work, shop, learn, and connect — with new opportunities and new problems like misinformation. This tech boom powered a strong 1990s economy under President Clinton, who reached the first balanced budget since 1969. Clinton also signed NAFTA (1993), a free-trade deal supporters praised for growing markets and critics blamed for lost factory jobs. He was impeached in 1998 but acquitted and stayed popular.

● **Tennessee:** A Tennessean helped build the internet age. Al Gore Jr. — congressman, senator, and Bill Clinton's vice president — was one of the earliest political champions of the internet, sponsoring the High Performance Computing Act of 1991 that helped fund the network's expansion into the tool the whole world now uses. From Cordell Hull and the UN to Al Gore and the internet, Tennessee kept turning up at the center of the systems that connect the modern world.

Toward a more perfect union — the cycle

- **Problem:** A technology revolution and globalization transformed the economy, creating winners and losers.
- **Head out of the sand:** Tech innovators, workers displaced by trade, and policymakers shaping the new economy.
- **Voice raised:** Markets, trade agreements (NAFTA), and public debate over globalization.
- **Government response:** Government promoted free trade and internet growth; the costs to some workers were addressed only partly.
- **Still unfinished:** How to share technology's and trade's benefits — and manage their harms — is a defining current issue.

✓ **Check:** Describe how communication technology changed from the 1970s to today, with two examples, including one benefit and one challenge. Then explain the Clinton-era economy and the debate over NAFTA. How did technology and the economy connect?

Show what you know:

- Make a timeline of communication tech from the 1970s to now, marking one benefit and one cost of each stage.
- Argue both sides of NAFTA: the worker who lost a factory job and the shopper who paid less.

- Debate: has the technology revolution done more to connect Americans or to divide them?
Use evidence.
-

Analyze the September 11, 2001 attacks and the War on Terror they set in motion.

🔊 On an ordinary bright Tuesday morning, the country you've been studying for ten units was attacked at home — not by an army, but by nineteen men with box cutters and a plan of unimaginable cruelty. Nearly 3,000 people died in a couple of hours, on live television, in front of the whole world. If you know anyone old enough, ask them where they were that morning; they will remember exactly. September 11, 2001 is the day the modern era turned, and its consequences are still shaping the world you live in.

Archive brings the crew above lower Manhattan, where smoke still rises from the ruins. She's quiet for a long moment. 'A ten-year-old named Maya watched this on a classroom TV,' she says. 'Her whole generation grew up in the world that began that morning. We look at this carefully, and with respect for the dead.'

GROUP

September 11 • the day everything changed

On September 11, 2001, the terrorist group al-Qaeda hijacked four passenger planes. They flew two into the World Trade Center's twin towers in New York, which collapsed; one into the Pentagon; and a fourth crashed in a Pennsylvania field after passengers fought back. Nearly 3,000 people were killed — the deadliest terrorist attack in American history and the deadliest attack on U.S. soil since Pearl Harbor. The nation reeled in shock and grief, and then in unity. In response, President George W. Bush launched the 'War on Terror,' beginning a war in Afghanistan against al-Qaeda and its protectors, and later a controversial war in Iraq. America's sense of safety, unshaken since the Cold War, was gone.



ERA-FRIEND

Maya • growing up after

Maya was a child on 9/11, and she barely remembers a world before it. Her whole life has been lived in the aftermath: the airport security lines, the two long wars, the arguments about how to stay safe. She learns that the response reached into daily life at home, too. Congress passed the USA PATRIOT Act, which expanded the government's power to surveil people in the name of security — and sparked a hard, ongoing debate that echoes all the way back through this course: how much freedom should a democracy trade for safety when it's afraid? Maya's generation didn't choose that question, but they inherited it, and they're the ones who will have to keep answering it.



📷 The ruins of the World Trade Center — 'Ground Zero' — after the September 11, 2001 attacks that killed nearly 3,000 people and launched the War on Terror.

'World Trade Center Ground Zero debris, New York City.' Photograph, September 28, 2001. U.S. government (public domain).

💡 This is Ground Zero — the ruins of the World Trade Center — weeks after the attack. Ask: this unit has shown you other moments when fear tempted America to trade away liberty (the Red Scare, internment). How should a free country protect itself from a real threat without losing what makes it free?

In plain words: On September 11, 2001, the terrorist group al-Qaeda hijacked four planes, crashing two into the World Trade Center (which collapsed), one into the Pentagon, and one in Pennsylvania. Nearly 3,000 people died — the deadliest terrorist attack in U.S. history. In response, President George W. Bush launched the 'War on Terror,' with wars in Afghanistan and Iraq. At home, Congress passed the USA PATRIOT Act, expanding government surveillance and sparking a lasting debate about the balance between security and civil liberties — the same tension seen in the Red Scare and Japanese American internment.

● **Tennessee:** After 9/11, Tennessee's soldiers went to war again. Fort Campbell's 101st Airborne Division — the same 'Screaming Eagles' who had fought in the Gulf War — deployed to Afghanistan as America struck back against al-Qaeda and the Taliban. Once more, Tennessee-based troops were among the first sent into the nation's newest conflict, and Tennessee families joined the whole country in the long, hard years of the War on Terror.

Toward a more perfect union — the cycle

- **Problem:** A devastating terrorist attack forced the country to defend itself while protecting its freedoms.
- **Head out of the sand:** A grieving, unified public and leaders deciding how to respond.
- **Voice raised:** National mourning, a congressional authorization of force, and debate over the PATRIOT Act.
- **Government response:** The U.S. launched the War on Terror and expanded surveillance powers, with lasting debate over the trade-offs.
- **Still unfinished:** Balancing security and liberty in an age of terrorism remains unresolved.

✓ **Check:** Explain what happened on September 11, 2001, and how the United States responded. Then explain the debate the USA PATRIOT Act raised. How does that debate connect to earlier moments in this course?

Show what you know:

- Write a respectful reflection on how to honor the nearly 3,000 people killed on 9/11.
 - Compare the security-vs-liberty debate after 9/11 with the Red Scare or internment from earlier units.
 - Debate: how much freedom should a democracy trade for safety in the face of a real threat? Use evidence from this course.
-

Spread 9 • US.93, US.95

Analyze the breaking of barriers for women and minorities in government, culminating in the election of the first African American president — and close the arc of the whole course.

🔔 Go back to Unit 1. In 1877, a Black Southerner couldn't safely vote, a woman couldn't vote at all, and the idea of either one leading the country was unthinkable. Now fast-forward to a freezing January day in 2009, when nearly two million people crowd Washington to watch a Black man raise his hand and become President of the United States — in the same century a Memphis balcony took the movement's greatest leader. This is where 130 years of this story arrives. Not at perfection. But a very long way from where it began.

Last stop. Archive brings the whole crew — and you — to the steps of the Capitol on January 20, 2009. Maya, casting her first vote just weeks before, is somewhere in that vast crowd, her grandmother Etta's story in her bones. 'This is where the map runs out,' Archive says softly. 'From here on, the story is yours to write.'

INSTITUTION

Breaking the barriers

Across these decades, Americans who had been locked out of power finally reached its highest levels. In 1981 Sandra Day O'Connor became the first woman ever to sit on the Supreme Court. Colin Powell and Condoleezza Rice became the first African Americans to serve as Secretary of State, running the nation's foreign policy. Hillary Clinton became a senator, Secretary of State, and a major presidential candidate, and Nancy Pelosi became the first woman Speaker of the House, second in line to the presidency. Each 'first' widened the circle of who could lead in America — chipping away, appointment by appointment and election by election, at the long assumption that power belonged to only one kind of person.



ERA-FRIEND

Maya • her family's whole story, in one vote

Maya casts her first-ever vote in 2008, and she does not cast it lightly, because she carries a whole family history to the ballot box. Her great-great-grandparents rode the Great Migration north (Unit 4). Her grandmother Etta sat in at a Nashville lunch counter and risked a Freedom Ride (Unit 9). Now Maya votes for Barack Obama, who in January 2009 becomes the first African American president of the United States — elected, remarkably, amid the worst financial crisis since the Great Depression. As president, he signs the Affordable Care Act, extending health coverage to millions, and governs through unusually fierce partisan division. For Maya, standing in that inauguration crowd, it isn't just history. It's her grandmother's dream, and it's proof — imperfect, contested, but real — of how far the country has come.



📷 President Barack Obama at his inauguration, January 20, 2009 — the first African American president, elected amid the 2008 financial crisis.

'President Barack Obama after his inaugural address, U.S. Capitol.' Photograph, January 20, 2009. U.S. government (public domain).

💡 This is Barack Obama's inauguration, January 20, 2009 — the first African American president. Ask: this course began in 1877, when a Black American could not safely vote. Hold that beginning and this photograph in your mind at once. What does the distance between them tell you — and what does the distance still to go?

MORE FROM THE RECORD



Justice Sandra Day O'Connor, appointed in 1981 as the first woman on the U.S. Supreme

Court — one of many barriers broken in these decades.

In plain words: In recent decades, women and minorities reached the highest levels of American government for the first time: Sandra Day O'Connor (first woman on the Supreme Court, 1981), Colin Powell and Condoleezza Rice (first Black Secretaries of State), and Hillary Clinton and Nancy Pelosi (first woman Speaker of the House). The biggest milestone came in 2008, when Barack Obama was elected — amid the worst financial crisis since the Great Depression — as the first African American president. He signed the Affordable Care Act, covering millions more Americans, and governed amid sharp partisan division. It marked how far the country had come since 1877 — though the work was not finished.

● **Tennessee:** Tennessee's own long journey is folded into this closing. The state that was the site of the movement's tragedy — King's assassination in Memphis in 1968 — took part, four decades later, in the elections that sent the first African American president to the White House. Tennessee's story across this course — from Reconstruction's broken promises through the Nashville sit-ins to today — mirrors the nation's: real, hard-won progress, still unevenly shared, still unfinished. The measure of how far we've come is also a map of how far there is to go.

Toward a more perfect union — the cycle

- **Problem:** For most of American history, the highest offices were closed to women and racial minorities.
- **Head out of the sand:** Generations of activists, voters, and the barrier-breakers themselves.
- **Voice raised:** Elections, appointments, and the long civil-rights and women's movements behind them.
- **Government response:** By the 2000s, women and minorities held the highest offices, up to the presidency itself.
- **Still unfinished:** Full equality and representation remain incomplete — the union is more perfect, not perfect.

✓ **Check:** Give three examples of women or minorities breaking barriers in government. Then explain why Obama's 2008 election was historic, and its context. Finally: looking across the whole course from 1877 to 2009, has the country moved closer to 'a more perfect union'? Defend your answer with evidence from at least two units.

Show what you know:

- Create a 'then and now' spread comparing who could hold power in 1877 (Unit 1) and in 2009 (Unit 10).
- Trace one family's possible path across the whole course — Great Migration, civil rights, first vote for Obama — as a short narrative.

- Write your own answer to the course's final question: is the union becoming more perfect, and what will YOU do about the part that isn't?

Toward a more perfect union

This is where the whole course comes home. For ten units and 130 years, you've measured America against its own founding promise — 'a more perfect union,' 'liberty and justice for all' — and watched the country climb, stumble, and climb again toward it, never arriving. The modern era is that same story, still running: real progress (barriers broken, a safety net built, a Cold War ended peacefully, a Black president elected) tangled up with real conflict, real failures, and questions still fiercely unsettled. The point of this whole book has never been to hand you a verdict — it's to hand you the facts, the many perspectives, and the trust to make up your own mind. The union is more perfect than it was in 1877. It is not perfect. And the reason this unit ends at the present is that the next chapter isn't written yet. It's yours.

Closing question: You've now traveled the entire arc, from 1877 to today. Looking back across all ten units, argue whether the United States has, on balance, moved closer to its founding promise of 'a more perfect union' — using at least three moments from different units as evidence. Then, because this is your country now: name one part of the promise you think is still unfinished, and one thing your generation could do about it. There's no answer key. This one is yours to write.

This unit on the Arc of the Union

You decide: did each of these move the country **toward** its founding promise of liberty and equality for all — or away from it? There's no answer key — mark your own read and defend it with evidence.

Year	Milestone	What happened	Your call
1965	The Great Society builds a safety net	Medicare, Medicaid, and the War on Poverty expand the federal safety net.	

Year	Milestone	What happened	Your call
1974	Watergate: the system holds	Nixon resigns; the courts and Congress prove no one is above the law, but trust erodes.	
1970	The environmental movement wins protection	Earth Day and new laws make protecting the environment a permanent national duty.	
1991	The Cold War ends peacefully	The Soviet Union collapses; the long Cold War ends without the feared catastrophe.	
2001	The September 11 attacks	The deadliest terrorist attack in U.S. history launches the War on Terror.	
2009	The first African American president	Barack Obama's election marks how far the nation has come since 1877 — and how far remains.	